

LONG-FORM WRITING SYSTEM

Writing a 60,000-Word Book with AI

A practical system for planning, drafting, controlling, and revising a long-form manuscript without losing the plot - or your voice.

PLAN	DRAFT	CONTROL	REVISE
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For fiction and nonfiction authors

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How to Use This Guide

Build the documents as you move through the six phases. The templates are working pages, not bonus material. Print them, copy them into your writing system, or adapt their fields to your preferred tool.

Copyright and responsibility

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Contents

How to Use This Guide	2
Copyright and responsibility	2
Contents	3
Writing a 60,000-Word Book with AI	8
A practical system for planning, drafting, controlling, and revising a long-form manuscript without losing the plot - or your voice	8
What this guide will help you build	8
Who this is for	9
One workflow, two branches	9
Why long-form AI manuscripts fail	10
The six-part method	10
The author's job	11
A note on the 60,000-word target	11
How to use this guide	11
Part I: Build the Foundation	12
1. Write the book promise	12
2. Define the reader precisely	12
3. Define the reader transformation	13
4. Build the master project bible	13
5. Create a usable voice sheet	15
6. Separate decisions from open questions	16
7. Establish source standards before drafting	16
8. Set boundaries for sensitive guidance	17

9. Build the fiction foundation	17
10. Build the nonfiction foundation	17
11. Approve the foundation	18
Part II: Architect 60,000 Words	18
1. Choose the book's large movement	18
2. Build 20-30 chapters	19
3. Give every chapter one primary job	20
4. Map dependencies	20
5. Assign word budgets	21
6. Create chapter briefs	21
7. Stress-test the structure	22
8. Use AI to test architecture without surrendering it	23
9. Running nonfiction architecture: biblical manhood	23
10. Compact fiction architecture	24
11. Approve the architecture	25
Part III: Build the Manuscript Operating System	25
1. The master project bible	25
2. The approved outline	26
3. The chapter brief	26
4. The style and voice sheet	26
5. The decision log	26
6. The continuity tracker	27
7. The open-questions list	28
8. The revision ledger	28
9. The claim-and-source ledger	28

10. The biblical citation and interpretation ledger	29
11. The context-reset packet	29
12. The chapter handoff	30
13. Document ownership and update rhythm	30
14. A practical folder structure	30
15. Operating-system audit	30

Part IV: Draft Chapter by Chapter **31**

The drafting loop	31
1. Review before generating	31
2. Resolve blocking decisions	31
3. Build the internal map	32
4. Generate options before prose	32
5. Draft one section	33
6. Review the section	33
7. Approve, revise, or reject	34
8. Update the system	34
When to start a clean conversation	34
Fiction drafting controls	34
Nonfiction drafting controls	35
Biblical-project drafting controls	35
Managing word count during drafting	36
A complete chapter session	37
Chapter handoff checklist	37

Part V: Revise in Controlled Passes **37**

Pass 1: Promise and structure pass	37
Pass 2: Chapter-purpose and sequence pass	38
Pass 3: Continuity or argument pass	38
Pass 4: Evidence and citation pass	38
Pass 5: Voice and audience pass	38
Pass 6: Repetition and compression pass	39
Pass 7: AI-tell pass	39
Pass 8: Sentence-level polish	39
Pass 9: Read-aloud and final human review	39
Revision requests that work	40
Revision gate	40
Part VI: Assemble and Finish the Manuscript	40
1. Establish version control	40
2. Create a chapter-status dashboard	41
3. Assemble approved chapters	41
4. Repair transitions	41
5. Complete front and back matter	41
6. Prepare the beta-reader edition	42
7. Triage feedback	42
8. Complete the final audit	42
9. Export and inspect	43
Worked Examples: From Decision to Draft	43
Nonfiction example: Strength Under Control	43
Fiction example: Mara and the Flood Map	45
What both examples prove	46

Working Templates	47
Prompt Framework Library	65
Final Principle	70

Writing a 60,000-Word Book with AI

A practical system for planning, drafting, controlling, and revising a long-form manuscript without losing the plot - or your voice

AI can give you a paragraph in seconds. A book is a different problem.

A book has memory. It makes promises in chapter one that must still matter in chapter eighteen. It introduces terms, people, sources, themes, tensions, and questions that must remain consistent across tens of thousands of words. It needs movement without hurry, repetition without redundancy, and enough variation to keep the reader awake without making the manuscript feel as if six different people wrote it.

That is why the most common instruction for AI-assisted writing - "write me a book about this" - usually produces something that resembles a book from across the room but collapses when you begin reading. The sentences may be grammatical. The chapters may have titles. The tone may sound confident. Yet the manuscript circles the same ideas, forgets its own decisions, invents details, overexplains obvious points, and smooths every voice into the same polished average.

The answer is not a longer prompt. The answer is a writing system.

Do not ask AI to remember the whole book. Build a system that remembers it for you.

This guide shows you that system. It is designed for a manuscript of approximately 60,000 words, but the method scales down to a short practical book and up to a longer novel. It works whether you use ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, another writing assistant, or several tools over the life of a project. The interface will change. The author's responsibilities will not.

What this guide will help you build

By the end, you will have:

- A clear book promise and reader transformation
- A master project bible that records the book's stable decisions
- A 60,000-word architecture divided into purposeful parts and chapters
- A word budget that makes the size of the project manageable
- Chapter briefs that tell each chapter what job it must perform
- A context-reset packet for beginning a clean AI conversation without losing the project
- Fiction continuity tools for characters, timelines, settings, setup, and payoff
- Nonfiction tools for claims, evidence, sources, terminology, and applications
- A controlled chapter drafting loop
- A revision plan built from separate editorial passes
- A final assembly and manuscript audit process

You will also get reusable worksheets, trackers, and prompt frameworks. They are not magic commands. They are containers for your decisions. A weak decision written into a perfect prompt is still a weak decision. A strong decision can survive several tools, several drafts, and a fresh conversation.

Who this is for

This guide is for writers who want AI to increase their range or momentum without surrendering authorship.

You may be starting your first novel. You may have expertise but struggle to organize it into a nonfiction book. You may have a half-finished manuscript that becomes less coherent every time you ask an AI assistant to "continue." You may be helping someone turn years of teaching, research, or lived experience into a book without flattening that person's voice.

This guide assumes that the author remains responsible for what the book says. AI can help you explore structures, expose gaps, compare options, draft from an approved brief, and audit a manuscript. It cannot decide what you believe, which claim is true, what a character ultimately means, which source deserves trust, or whether a piece of advice is safe for a reader.

WARNING

AI output is not verification. A model can state an invented quotation, source, historical fact, statistic, or Bible verse with the same confidence it uses for a correct one. Every factual or quoted element must be checked against a reliable source outside the model.

One workflow, two branches

Fiction and nonfiction share more process than writers sometimes expect. Both need a promise, a structure, a reader experience, a controlled vocabulary, chapter purpose, pacing, continuity, and revision. Both benefit from external memory documents. Both fail when the draft outruns the author's decisions.

The differences matter, so this guide marks them clearly.

FICTION

Fiction guidance focuses on premise, genre promise, point of view, character desire, conflict, scene change, timeline, setting rules, emotional continuity, setup, payoff, and the ending.

NONFICTION

Nonfiction guidance focuses on thesis, reader problem, evidence, source quality, terminology, argument sequence, examples, objections, application, and factual verification.

BIBLICAL PROJECT

The recurring nonfiction example is a book defining biblical manhood for sons and young men ages 13-21. It demonstrates how to control a complex, sensitive, source-dependent project. The example is about writing process. It does not choose a denomination or settle theological disagreements for the author.

The biblical project requires additional distinctions:

- What the biblical text says
- What the immediate context establishes
- How the author interprets the passage
- Which theological conclusion the author draws
- How that conclusion is applied to a modern reader

Collapsing those steps is how an application begins to masquerade as a quotation or an interpretation begins to sound like the only possible reading. A responsible manuscript makes the transitions visible.

Why long-form AI manuscripts fail

The model loses the center

An AI conversation accumulates material, not understanding. As the exchange grows, the assistant may preserve recent instructions while weakening earlier ones. The book's original promise becomes one influence among many. A chapter that began as "teach a young reader how responsibility grows from identity" becomes a general motivational essay because motivational language is easier to generate than a disciplined argument.

The outline becomes decoration

Many writers make an outline, then draft without using it as a control document. Chapters grow because the prose sounds good, not because the chapter needs the material. The AI introduces new themes, the author accepts them, and the manuscript acquires several competing centers.

An approved outline is not a suggestion. It is the current map. You may revise it, but you revise it deliberately and record the decision.

Every chapter rediscovers the book

Without chapter briefs, the assistant must infer the purpose of each chapter from a broad description of the whole project. The result is repeated introductions, repeated definitions, repeated encouragement, and repeated conclusions. Each chapter sounds as if it is the first chapter because the model keeps rebuilding context from scratch.

Voice becomes a list of adjectives

"Warm, engaging, authoritative, conversational, and inspiring" is not a usable voice specification. It describes nearly every commercial nonfiction request. A real voice sheet contains sentence tendencies, degree of directness, treatment of uncertainty, vocabulary boundaries, humor rules, examples of preferred phrasing, and patterns to avoid.

Drafting and editing happen at the same time

When you ask for structure, originality, evidence, rhythm, perfect sentences, and final polish in one pass, the model optimizes for the easiest visible target: fluent prose. Fluent prose can hide a weak chapter. Long-form quality improves when you separate decisions into passes.

Verification is mistaken for revision

An assistant can improve the wording of a false claim. It can make an invented source sound more credible. It can explain why its own fabricated quotation appears plausible. Revision and verification are different jobs. Verification returns to the source.

The six-part method

This guide moves through six phases:

- 1. Foundation:** Define what the book promises, who it serves, what it believes, and what it will not attempt.
- 2. Architecture:** Turn the promise into parts, chapters, dependencies, and word budgets.
- 3. Operating system:** Create the external documents that preserve decisions and continuity.
- 4. Drafting:** Produce one controlled section at a time from an approved chapter brief.
- 5. Revision:** Evaluate structure, continuity, evidence, voice, repetition, and prose in separate passes.
- 6. Assembly:** Combine chapters, repair transitions, prepare readers and reviewers, and complete the final audit.

The process is intentionally less exciting than asking for a complete book and watching thousands of words appear. It is also far more likely to produce a manuscript worth putting your name on.

The author's job

The author decides:

- What the book is trying to do
- Which reader it serves
- Which structure best delivers the promise
- Which claims and sources belong
- What the characters want and what their choices mean
- Which generated options are alive and which are merely competent
- When the manuscript is wrong, shallow, repetitive, or dishonest
- What remains after revision

AI can accelerate comparison. It can produce alternatives faster than a human can type them. It can notice patterns across material you provide. It can help you get unstuck. None of that removes the need for judgment. It increases the number of moments when judgment is required.

EXERCISE

Before continuing, finish this sentence without asking an AI assistant: "I am the author of this book because I am responsible for..." Keep the answer. It will become the first entry in your decision log.

A note on the 60,000-word target

Sixty thousand words is not a quality score. It is a planning constraint. A concise book should not be inflated to reach it, and a complex book should not be mutilated to stay under it. The number is useful because it forces you to distribute attention.

At 24 chapters, 60,000 words averages 2,500 words per chapter. At 20 chapters, it averages 3,000. At 30 chapters, it averages 2,000. Those averages create a budget, not a prison. An opening chapter may need 1,800 words while a central argument needs 3,400. The budget makes the trade visible.

When a chapter exceeds its budget, ask what happened. Did the chapter inherit material that belongs elsewhere? Is it carrying two jobs? Has a new idea entered the book without architectural approval? The word count is a diagnostic signal.

How to use this guide

Do not read the entire guide and then try to remember it. Build the documents as you go.

Complete the foundation before asking for chapter prose. Approve the architecture before expanding every chapter brief. Build the operating system before the manuscript becomes too large to control. Revise one dimension at a time. Keep a human-readable record of every major decision.

At any point, you should be able to answer five questions:

1. What promise is this book making?
2. What job is the current chapter doing?
3. What has already been decided?
4. What evidence or continuity information does this section depend on?
5. What decision must the author make next?

If you cannot answer them, generating more prose is usually the wrong next step.

Part I: Build the Foundation

A long manuscript begins before the first chapter. It begins when the author decides what kind of promise the book will make and what evidence will count as keeping it.

The foundation does not need to predict every sentence. It needs to keep future decisions from contradicting one another. It gives the book a center of gravity.

1. Write the book promise

The book promise is one sentence describing the experience or change the manuscript will deliver for a specific reader.

A useful promise includes:

- The reader
- The problem, desire, or experience
- The form of change
- The book's distinct approach

Weak promise: "This book is about becoming a better man."

Stronger promise: "This book helps young men ages 13-21 understand biblical manhood as a life of identity, responsibility, strength under control, service, and faithful action - through Scripture in context, honest modern situations, and practical choices."

The stronger version is still provisional. Terms such as "biblical manhood" and "strength under control" require definition. But it can guide architecture. It suggests what belongs and exposes what does not.

FICTION

A fiction promise describes the kind of experience the story will deliver. It includes genre, central tension, emotional movement, and the question that keeps the reader turning pages. "A grieving apprentice must cross a flooded city with the rival she blames for her brother's death" gives the story more control than "a fantasy adventure about forgiveness."

NONFICTION

A nonfiction promise describes a reader transformation. Avoid promising an outcome the book cannot guarantee. "Understand and practice" is more responsible than "become." The manuscript can offer principles, tools, and challenges. It cannot control the reader's life.

EXERCISE

Write three versions of the promise. Make one practical, one emotional, and one narrowly specific. Compare them. Choose the version that gives you the clearest standard for what to exclude.

2. Define the reader precisely

"Everyone" is not a reader profile. A book may reach people outside its intended audience, but the prose needs someone to face.

Record:

- Approximate age and life stage

- Existing knowledge
- Existing beliefs or expectations
- Immediate problems and private fears
- What language feels natural
- What language feels false, academic, childish, or patronizing
- What the reader is ready to do now
- What the reader is not yet prepared to carry

BIBLICAL PROJECT

Ages 13-21 is a wide range. A thirteen-year-old may depend on parents for nearly every major decision. A twenty-one-year-old may be working full time, studying away from home, dating seriously, caring for family members, or living independently. The project should choose a primary reader, such as a sixteen- or seventeen-year-old son, then use sidebars or examples that expand upward and downward.

Writing to the midpoint prevents the voice from becoming childish for older readers or inaccessible for younger ones. Scenarios can vary by stage:

- Younger: school, siblings, chores, sports, online behavior, early friendships
- Middle: driving, work, dating, academic pressure, independence, private habits
- Older: employment, college, money, serious relationships, leadership, living choices

The book should never confuse directness with contempt. Young readers can handle difficult ideas when the writer defines terms, respects their intelligence, and connects abstraction to life.

3. Define the reader transformation

The transformation is the path from the reader's starting state to a more capable state.

Use four columns:

- 1. Before:** What does the reader currently misunderstand, avoid, or lack?
- 2. Understand:** What should the reader be able to explain?
- 3. Practice:** What should the reader be able to do?
- 4. Continue:** What habits or questions should remain after the final page?

For the biblical-manhood project:

- Before: manhood is confused with age, dominance, toughness, sexual experience, income, or approval.
- Understand: biblical manhood is rooted in identity and expressed through responsibility, courage, restraint, service, integrity, and faithfulness.
- Practice: the reader can identify a responsible action in a real situation and take it.
- Continue: the reader has reflection habits, trusted adults, Scripture study practices, and a clearer standard for growth.

This transformation is an editorial test. If a chapter is interesting but does not move the reader along the path, it may belong in another book.

4. Build the master project bible

The project bible is the book's external memory. It stores stable decisions so they do not have to be reconstructed from an AI conversation.

The first version should contain:

Identity

- Working title and subtitle
- Book promise
- Primary and secondary readers
- Genre or category
- Target length
- Intended reading level and emotional register

Content boundaries

- What the book covers
- What it explicitly does not cover
- Terms that require definition
- Claims that require sources
- Sensitive areas requiring expert review

Structure

- Parts or acts
- Current chapter list
- The function of each part
- Major dependencies
- Planned ending

Voice

- Point of view
- Degree of directness
- Typical sentence length and rhythm
- Vocabulary level
- Humor policy
- Treatment of uncertainty
- Preferred and prohibited habits

Evidence or continuity

- Source hierarchy for nonfiction
- World rules for fiction
- Timeline anchors
- Character or terminology records
- Citation policy

Decision status

- Approved decisions
- Provisional decisions
- Open questions
- Rejected approaches and why they were rejected

The bible should be compact enough to review before every major session. The manuscript contains the full writing. The bible contains the decisions needed to produce it.

WARNING

Do not let the project bible become a warehouse. If you paste every brainstorm into it, the stable decisions disappear. Keep exploration in working notes. Promote only approved decisions into the bible.

5. Create a usable voice sheet

Voice becomes controllable when it is described through behavior rather than praise.

Instead of "clear and engaging," record instructions such as:

- Address the reader directly when asking for action, but do not use the reader's name.
- Prefer concrete nouns and active verbs.
- Define a theological or technical term before using it as shorthand.
- Use one strong example instead of three shallow examples.
- Admit uncertainty directly.
- Do not end every section with inspiration.
- Avoid "in today's world," "it's important to remember," and other generic transition phrases.
- Vary paragraph length, but keep most paragraphs under 140 words.
- Use questions to open reflection, not as decorative hooks.

Add short examples of language that sounds right and language that does not. The examples can come from the author's existing writing. If the author is developing a new voice, create samples, revise them manually, and approve only the sentences that feel truthful.

BIBLICAL PROJECT

The voice should be serious without becoming severe, masculine without performance, and pastoral without pretending to be the reader's pastor. It should distinguish challenge from shame. "You are responsible for your next choice" gives agency. "A real man would never struggle with this" punishes honesty and encourages concealment.

The voice sheet should prohibit:

- Mocking vulnerability
- Treating emotion as weakness
- Equating domination with leadership
- Promising that right behavior guarantees comfort, romance, success, or safety
- Using Scripture as a slogan without context
- Speaking as if every family, church, body, or developmental experience is identical

6. Separate decisions from open questions

AI is excellent at generating possibilities. That strength becomes a problem when possibilities quietly enter the manuscript as decisions.

Maintain three lists:

Approved

The book will define courage as faithful action in the presence of fear, not the absence of fear.

Provisional

The book may use a three-part progression: identity, practice, responsibility.

Open

Should the chapter on work come before or after the chapter on discipline?

Every drafting session should know which category it is working in. Do not ask for polished prose around an unresolved structural question. Ask for options, compare them, decide, and update the log.

7. Establish source standards before drafting

Nonfiction needs a source hierarchy. Decide what kinds of sources can support which kinds of claims.

A practical hierarchy may be:

1. Primary source or original text
2. Peer-reviewed or authoritative reference
3. Reputable scholarly or professional synthesis
4. Credible journalism or institutional publication
5. Personal account, used as an example rather than universal proof
6. AI-generated suggestion, treated only as a lead to verify

NONFICTION

For each factual claim, record the claim, source, source type, location, verification date, and status. A bibliography assembled from memory at the end cannot repair months of untracked drafting.

BIBLICAL PROJECT

The Bible is the primary text, but interpretation still requires decisions. Record:

- Passage reference
- Translation used for any direct quotation
- Immediate literary context
- Relevant historical or canonical context used by the author
- Observation from the text
- Interpretation adopted by the author
- Theological tradition or source informing that interpretation, when relevant
- Modern application
- Human reviewer and review status

Choose a translation policy. Options include using one primary translation throughout, comparing translations only when the wording matters, or paraphrasing while citing the reference. Do not blend wording from several translations into a quotation. Do not accept a model's memory of a verse. Open the source and check it.

8. Set boundaries for sensitive guidance

A book for young readers may touch mental health, abuse, sexuality, addiction, medical concerns, legal issues, family conflict, or spiritual authority. Decide what the book can responsibly do.

It may:

- Offer general principles
- Encourage the reader to seek trustworthy help
- Describe warning signs carefully
- Direct the reader toward qualified adults and professionals
- Acknowledge that some situations require protection rather than endurance

It should not:

- Diagnose the reader
- Tell a minor to conceal danger
- Treat abuse as a character-building opportunity
- Replace medical, legal, or mental-health care
- Promise spiritual certainty about a specific personal crisis

These boundaries belong in the project bible and the final review checklist.

9. Build the fiction foundation

FICTION

Record the following before expanding the outline:

- **Premise:** Who wants what, what opposes them, and what happens if they fail?
- **Genre promise:** What pleasures and expectations bring the reader to this kind of story?
- **Point of view:** Who can perceive and narrate each scene?
- **Character engine:** What does the protagonist want, need, fear, and misunderstand?
- **Opposition:** Who or what actively makes the goal difficult?
- **World rules:** What can and cannot happen?
- **Ending target:** What choice, cost, revelation, or change completes the story?

Do not ask AI to produce a detailed plot before these elements agree. A plot is not a pile of events. It is pressure applied to desire over time.

10. Build the nonfiction foundation

NONFICTION

Record:

- **Thesis:** The central claim the book will establish

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- **Reader problem:** The practical or intellectual problem the reader brings
 - **Argument path:** The sequence of ideas required to reach the conclusion
 - **Evidence standard:** What counts as support
 - **Counterarguments:** Which reasonable objections deserve treatment
 - **Application:** What the reader can do with the understanding
 - **Exclusions:** Questions the book acknowledges but will not settle

A nonfiction chapter should not exist only because the topic is interesting. It needs a place in the argument or transformation.

11. Approve the foundation

Before moving to architecture, perform a foundation review:

- Can the promise fit in one sentence?
- Does the primary reader feel like a person rather than a demographic?
- Is the transformation observable?
- Are key terms defined or scheduled for definition?
- Are content boundaries explicit?
- Are source and quotation rules recorded?
- Are sensitive areas flagged for human review?
- Does the voice sheet describe behavior?
- Are approved decisions separated from open questions?
- Can the author explain why this book should exist?

If the answers are weak, do not solve the problem with more chapters. Repair the foundation.

Part II: Architect 60,000 Words

Architecture turns a good intention into a reading experience. It decides when the reader learns something, when a question opens, when pressure increases, when a concept returns at a deeper level, and what must be true before the ending can work.

AI can propose structures quickly. It cannot know which structure best expresses your purpose until you define the criteria and choose among the options.

1. Choose the book's large movement

Begin with three to five parts. Each part should change the reader's position.

A nonfiction progression might move through:

1. Reframing the problem
2. Building the foundation
3. Practicing the principles
4. Applying them under pressure
5. Continuing without the book

A novel might move through:

1. Disruption
2. Pursuit
3. Escalation
4. Crisis
5. Consequence and resolution

Part names are not enough. Write a function statement:

By the end of Part II, the reader understands that responsibility grows from identity rather than from performance, and can distinguish responsibility from control.

or:

By the end of Act II, Mara has achieved the goal she thought would solve her problem, but the cost exposes the belief that has been driving her.

The function statement lets you test whether a proposed chapter belongs.

2. Build 20-30 chapters

A 60,000-word book often works well with 20-30 chapters. The range is not mandatory, but it creates units small enough to control and large enough to develop an idea or dramatic movement.

One workable nonfiction model is 24 chapters:

Part	Function	Chapters	Word budget
I	Name and reframe the problem	4	8,000
II	Establish identity and foundations	5	12,000
III	Build daily practices	6	15,000
IV	Apply principles under pressure	6	16,000
V	Integrate, continue, and conclude	3	9,000
Total		24	60,000

The average is 2,500 words per chapter, but averages should not flatten the book. The opening may be shorter. A difficult central chapter may be longer. The final chapter may need room for synthesis without introducing new arguments.

FICTION

A 24-chapter novel can use four six-chapter movements, three eight-chapter acts, or an irregular design driven by turning points. Do not force every act to the same length. Track the function and pressure of each movement.

NONFICTION

Nonfiction architecture follows dependencies. If the reader must understand identity before responsibility, and responsibility before leadership, the order should reflect that. A list of popular topics is not an argument.

3. Give every chapter one primary job

A chapter may do several things, but it needs one primary function.

Useful functions include:

- Define a key term
- Correct a misconception
- Establish evidence
- Introduce a practice
- Complicate an earlier idea
- Answer an objection
- Apply a principle under pressure
- Force a character choice
- Reveal information
- Reverse the apparent direction
- Pay off an earlier setup
- Prepare the ending

Write the function as a verb statement: "distinguish courage from fearlessness" is stronger than "courage."

If a chapter has two unrelated primary verbs, split it or decide which job serves the promise.

4. Map dependencies

A dependency is something the reader must know, believe, feel, or remember before a later chapter can work.

Create a simple map:

- Chapter 3 defines responsibility.
- Chapter 7 applies responsibility to work.
- Chapter 12 complicates responsibility when authority is unjust.
- Chapter 19 applies responsibility to leadership.
- Chapter 23 asks the reader to design a personal rule of life.

Now the repeated term has development. Without the map, the chapters may restate the same definition five times.

FICTION

Track information dependencies and emotional dependencies separately. A reader may know that a character lied before another character discovers it. A reconciliation may be logically possible but emotionally unearned because the necessary choices have not occurred.

NONFICTION

Track term dependencies, evidence dependencies, and practice dependencies. If a later exercise requires a distinction the manuscript never taught, the architecture has a gap.

5. Assign word budgets

Word budgets help you allocate attention before prose makes every idea feel indispensable.

For each chapter, record:

- Minimum viable length
- Target length
- Maximum length before review
- Number of major moves
- Space reserved for examples or scenes
- Space reserved for application or reflection

Example:

Element	Words
Opening situation	250
Scripture or source context	450
Core principle	650
Contemporary example	500
Objection or complication	300
Practical action	250
Reflection questions and transition	100
Target	2,500

This is not a formula every chapter must copy. It is an accounting tool. If the core principle takes 1,400 words, something else must change.

6. Create chapter briefs

A chapter brief is the contract between architecture and drafting. It should fit on one or two pages.

Include:

- Chapter number and working title
- Primary job
- Reader state at the beginning
- Reader state at the end
- Required prior knowledge
- Key claim or dramatic change
- Supporting evidence, sources, scenes, or examples
- Terms to define or preserve
- Material that must not enter this chapter
- Planned opening and closing movement
- Word budget

-
- Continuity or safety checks
 - Open author decisions

The brief should be approved before prose. AI may help generate options for the brief, but the author decides which job, evidence, and movement belong.

BIBLICAL PROJECT

A chapter brief for **Strength Under Control** might contain:

- **Primary job:** Replace the idea that strength means domination with strength governed by love, wisdom, and responsibility.
- **Beginning state:** The reader may associate manhood with physical power, emotional hardness, social control, or winning.
- **Ending state:** The reader can identify restraint as an active use of strength and name one situation where restraint requires courage.
- **Scripture plan:** References selected and checked by the author; context notes recorded in the citation ledger.
- **Modern situation:** A friend humiliates the reader online and the reader has the power to retaliate publicly.
- **Complication:** Restraint does not mean passivity in the face of abuse or danger.
- **Application:** Pause, seek wise counsel, choose a response that protects truth and people rather than pride.
- **Human review:** Theology, youth suitability, and safety review required.
- **Exclusions:** Do not diagnose anger disorders or give legal advice.

The brief controls what the chapter is allowed to become.

7. Stress-test the structure

Before drafting, try to break the outline.

The promise test

For every chapter, finish: "This chapter helps keep the book's promise by..." If the answer is vague, the chapter may be ornamental.

The repetition test

List each chapter's primary claim or change in one sentence. Highlight sentences that are essentially identical. Decide whether the repetition is developmental, reinforcing, or accidental.

The dependency test

Ask what the reader must already understand. Confirm that the prerequisite appears earlier and is strong enough to support the later use.

The missing-middle test

Many outlines have a strong opening and ending but a middle made of related topics. The middle should increase difficulty. Principles meet resistance. Characters pay costs. Objections grow stronger. Applications become less obvious.

The escalation test

FICTION

Does pressure increase? Do choices narrow? Do consequences accumulate? Does each major success create or expose another problem?

NONFICTION

Does the argument become more demanding? Does the reader move from understanding to practice, from simple cases to complicated ones, and from private choices to relational or public responsibility?

The ending test

Does the ending complete the book's movement rather than merely summarize the table of contents? The ending should return responsibility to the reader. It should not introduce a second book's worth of claims.

8. Use AI to test architecture without surrendering it

Give the assistant the book promise, reader profile, part functions, chapter list, and evaluation criteria. Ask for diagnosis, not replacement.

A useful request:

Review this architecture as a skeptical developmental editor. Identify duplicated chapter functions, missing dependencies, abrupt difficulty changes, chapters that do not advance the promise, and places where the middle loses momentum. Do not rewrite the outline. Return a table with the issue, evidence from the outline, consequence for the reader, and two possible author decisions.

The output is an audit. It does not become the new outline automatically.

WARNING

When an assistant recommends adding a chapter, ask what existing chapter should shrink, move, or disappear. Uncontrolled addition is the easiest way for a 60,000-word plan to become an 85,000-word draft with no stronger center.

9. Running nonfiction architecture: biblical manhood

The following progression is an example, not a theological prescription.

Part I: What manhood is not

1. The question beneath the stereotypes
2. Manhood is not age, image, dominance, or approval
3. Identity before performance
4. Responsibility without control

Part II: Foundations

5. Strength under control
6. Courage in the presence of fear
7. Integrity when nobody is watching
8. Discipline and the direction of desire
9. Wisdom, counsel, and teachability

Part III: Daily practice

10. Work and stewardship
11. Speech and truth
12. Friendship and loyalty
13. Family responsibility
14. Technology and private choices
15. Caring for body and mind

Part IV: Pressure and relationships

16. Anger, conflict, and repair
17. Attraction, sexuality, and dignity
18. Dating and boundaries
19. Failure, confession, and change
20. Authority, injustice, and conscience
21. Leadership as service

Part V: Continuing

22. Choosing community and mentors
23. Building a rule of life
24. Becoming faithful over time

This architecture contains 24 chapters and a visible movement: false definitions, foundations, ordinary practice, difficult pressure, and continuing formation.

It also reveals editorial questions:

- Is "caring for body and mind" within the author's competence, and which reviewers are needed?
- Does the sexuality chapter require separate versions or sidebars for different ages?
- How will the book address readers without a safe father, church, or family environment?
- Which tradition informs the treatment of authority, leadership, and sexuality?
- How will disagreement be acknowledged without turning the book into a survey of every position?

Those questions belong in the decision log before drafting.

10. Compact fiction architecture

FICTION

For comparison, imagine a novel about Mara, a teenage mapmaker in a city that floods a little higher each year. She believes her missing brother abandoned the family. When she discovers his coded maps, she must work with the rival apprentice she blames for his disappearance.

The architectural spine might be:

- **Part I - Disruption:** A flood destroys Mara's workshop; the coded map appears.
- **Part II - Pursuit:** Mara and the rival follow the map through closed districts and uncover her brother's investigation.

-
- **Part III - Escalation:** Evidence suggests the city's flood defenses are being manipulated; Mara's certainty about her brother begins to fail.
 - **Part IV - Crisis:** Stopping the next flood requires trusting the rival and revealing a family secret that will destroy her public identity.
 - **Part V - Consequence:** Mara chooses truth over vindication, saves part of the city, and accepts that repair is not the same as restoration.

The project bible records world rules, map logic, flood timeline, character knowledge, and the truth about the brother. Chapter briefs control when each clue appears and what changes because of it.

11. Approve the architecture

Do not begin full drafting until you can answer yes:

- Does every part change the reader's position?
- Does every chapter have one primary job?
- Do the chapters form a sequence rather than a shelf of topics?
- Are important dependencies mapped?
- Is the middle more demanding than the beginning?
- Does the word budget total approximately 60,000 words?
- Are fiction continuity or nonfiction source needs visible?
- Are sensitive chapters flagged for qualified review?
- Does the ending fulfill the promise?
- Can each chapter now receive a precise chapter brief?

Architecture will change during drafting. That is not failure. The goal is to make every change visible, deliberate, and connected to the book's promise.

Part III: Build the Manuscript Operating System

A long manuscript needs a memory that exists outside any AI conversation. The operating system is a small collection of documents that records what the book is, what has been decided, what each chapter must do, and what changed during drafting.

The point is not paperwork. The point is controlled forgetting. You should not need to carry the whole book in your head or paste the whole manuscript into every session. Each task receives the smallest accurate packet of context it needs.

1. The master project bible

The project bible stores stable decisions: promise, reader, scope, voice, key definitions, high-level structure, evidence policy, continuity rules, and sensitive boundaries.

Update it only when a project-level decision changes. Do not add every sentence, research note, or brainstorming option. When a decision changes, record the date, the old decision, the new decision, and the reason.

Use the project bible at the start of architecture, chapter briefing, developmental revision, and any clean conversation.

2. The approved outline

The outline stores the current sequence of parts and chapters. Every chapter entry includes its primary job, dependency, target word count, and relationship to the book promise.

The outline is approved, not frozen. A change requires an architectural reason. Record moves, additions, mergers, and deletions in the decision log before drafting proceeds.

WARNING

Do not let an AI assistant quietly revise the outline while drafting prose. If a draft introduces a new central idea, stop and decide whether the architecture should change.

3. The chapter brief

The chapter brief is the immediate source of truth for a drafting session. It states the chapter's job, reader movement, required evidence or scenes, exclusions, opening, closing, word budget, and unresolved decisions.

The assistant receives the chapter brief. It does not receive permission to redefine the chapter.

At the end of drafting, compare the result to the brief. If the chapter changed for a good reason, update the brief and decision log. Do not rewrite history by pretending the change was always intended.

4. The style and voice sheet

The voice sheet describes observable writing behavior. Keep it short enough to use repeatedly.

Include:

- Point of view and relationship to the reader
- Degree of formality and directness
- Sentence and paragraph tendencies
- Vocabulary boundaries
- Treatment of uncertainty
- Humor and metaphor rules
- Preferred examples
- Repeated phrases and structures to avoid
- Two or three approved samples

Update the sheet after a voice revision reveals a useful rule. Do not update it to justify accidental drift.

5. The decision log

The decision log prevents the book from relitigating the same questions.

Each entry contains:

- Date
- Question
- Options considered
- Decision
- Reason
- Documents affected

-
- Review trigger, if any

Example:

Question: *Who is the primary reader within ages 13-21?*

Decision: *Write to a sixteen- or seventeen-year-old son, with examples marked for younger and older readers.*

Reason: *A single developmental center creates a consistent voice while sidebars preserve range.*

Affected: *Reader profile, voice sheet, examples, chapter briefs, youth review.*

When an assistant offers an option that was previously rejected, the log gives you the reason without rebuilding the discussion.

6. The continuity tracker

FICTION

The continuity tracker records facts the story must preserve:

- Character appearance and physical limitations
- Relationships and forms of address
- Knowledge by character and chapter
- Objects, clues, injuries, promises, debts, and secrets
- Setting rules and travel time
- Scene date, time, weather, and location
- Setups and planned payoffs

Update it after every approved scene or chapter. Drafting from memory invites contradictions.

NONFICTION

Nonfiction continuity includes:

- Defined terms and their exact meanings
- Examples already used
- Claims promised for later treatment
- Objections raised and answered
- Practices introduced
- Terminology choices
- Cross-references and dependencies

A nonfiction manuscript can contradict itself without changing a character's eye color. It happens when "responsibility" means ownership in one chapter and authority in another.

7. The open-questions list

Open questions are decisions that block future work but do not need an answer yet.

Give each question:

- Owner
- Deadline or trigger
- Chapters affected
- Safe work that can continue meanwhile

An open question should not be hidden inside a draft comment. Centralize it. When it is resolved, move the answer to the decision log and update affected documents.

8. The revision ledger

The revision ledger tracks problems without forcing the author to solve them during drafting.

Record:

- Location
- Problem type
- Description
- Severity
- Revision pass
- Dependencies
- Status

Example: "Chapter 8 repeats the definition from Chapter 3" belongs in the repetition pass. "Chapter 8 relies on a claim without a source" belongs in the evidence pass. Separating the problems protects drafting momentum and produces cleaner revision.

9. The claim-and-source ledger

NONFICTION

For every meaningful factual claim, record:

- Claim ID
- Exact claim or narrow summary
- Chapter and section
- Source title and creator
- Source type
- Publication details
- Exact location: page, section, timestamp, or stable URL
- Whether the source directly supports the wording
- Verification date
- Quotation and permission status
- Notes or limitations

An AI-generated source suggestion begins with status **lead only**. It becomes usable only after a human opens the source and verifies it.

Do not cite search snippets, summaries of unread sources, or a model's description of a source.

10. The biblical citation and interpretation ledger

BIBLICAL PROJECT

This ledger prevents Scripture reference, interpretation, and application from collapsing into one unreviewed statement.

Record:

- Passage reference
- Translation used for direct quotation
- Verified wording and location
- Immediate context
- Observation from the text
- Interpretation adopted by the author
- Alternative interpretation requiring acknowledgment
- Theological source or tradition, when relevant
- Principle drawn
- Modern application proposed
- Audience and safety concern
- Human reviewer
- Review status

The ledger is not a substitute for study. It is evidence that study and review occurred.

11. The context-reset packet

The context-reset packet starts a clean AI conversation without pasting the entire manuscript.

It contains:

1. Book promise and primary reader
2. Current part and chapter
3. Relevant project-bible rules
4. Approved chapter brief
5. Relevant continuity or source records
6. A short summary of prior chapters needed for this task
7. Approved voice sample
8. Exact task
9. Required output format
10. Decisions the model must not make

Aim for the smallest packet that is still accurate. Extra context is not automatically helpful. Irrelevant material competes with the current task.

12. The chapter handoff

At the end of every approved chapter, create a chapter handoff summary:

- What the chapter accomplished
- Key claims, scenes, or changes
- New definitions or facts
- Decisions made during drafting
- Continuity and source updates
- Promises made to later chapters
- Open problems
- Exact ending state

The handoff becomes input to the next chapter brief and to later structural review.

13. Document ownership and update rhythm

Use this rhythm:

- **Before a drafting session:** Review project bible, approved outline, chapter brief, and relevant trackers.
- **During drafting:** Record new questions and potential revision issues without derailing the session.
- **After approving a section:** Update continuity or source records.
- **After approving a chapter:** Write the handoff and update the chapter status.
- **After an architectural change:** Update outline, briefs, project bible if needed, and decision log.
- **Before a new conversation:** Build a context-reset packet from current documents.

Only one version of each control document should be current. Archive old versions with dates. Do not keep several files called "final."

14. A practical folder structure

Use a structure that remains understandable without special software:

```
Book Project/  
00 Project Bible/  
01 Architecture/  
02 Chapter Briefs/  
03 Drafts/  
04 Trackers and Ledgers/  
05 Sources/  
06 Revision/  
07 Assembly/  
99 Archive/
```

Name drafts consistently: `C07\_v03\_2026-09-15.docx` is more useful than `chapter seven newest final really final.docx`.

15. Operating-system audit

Before drafting, confirm:

- The current project bible is identifiable.

-
- The outline and chapter brief agree.
 - The voice sheet contains examples and prohibitions.
 - Decisions and open questions are separated.
 - Fiction continuity or nonfiction source records are ready.
 - The biblical citation ledger distinguishes text, interpretation, and application.
 - A new conversation can be started from a context-reset packet.
 - Every approved chapter will end with a handoff.

If these documents feel heavy, simplify them. Do not remove the decisions they preserve.

Part IV: Draft Chapter by Chapter

The drafting unit is not the book. It is not even always the chapter. The safest unit is a purposeful section small enough to evaluate against an approved brief.

This part describes the drafting loop used for every chapter.

The drafting loop

1. Review the project controls.
2. Resolve blocking author decisions.
3. Divide the chapter into beats, scenes, or argument moves.
4. Generate options before prose when useful.
5. Draft one controlled section.
6. Review the section against the brief and evidence.
7. Approve, revise, or reject it.
8. Update trackers and create the chapter handoff.

1. Review before generating

Open the project bible, outline entry, chapter brief, voice sheet, and relevant trackers. Do not rely on what you remember from the last session.

Ask:

- What is this chapter's one primary job?
- What must change for the reader or character?
- Which material is required?
- Which material is excluded?
- What must remain consistent?
- What decision belongs to the author before drafting begins?

If the chapter brief is vague, repair it. Generating prose will not clarify an unresolved purpose.

2. Resolve blocking decisions

Examples of blocking decisions:

-
- Which interpretation or evidence standard will the author use?
 - Which character makes the irreversible choice?
 - Is the chapter primarily explanation or application?
 - Does this scene reveal the secret or only increase suspicion?
 - Is the reader being challenged, reassured, or equipped?

Ask the assistant for contrasting options with consequences. Then decide and update the log.

Do not ask the model to choose a theological conclusion, moral stance, final plot meaning, or personal testimony for you.

3. Build the internal map

A nonfiction chapter can be divided into argument moves:

1. Opening situation or question
2. Misconception
3. Source or evidence in context
4. Principle
5. Example
6. Objection or complication
7. Application
8. Reflection and transition

A fiction chapter can be divided into scenes or scene beats:

1. Immediate goal
2. Obstacle
3. Escalation
4. Choice
5. Consequence
6. New story state

The internal map prevents the assistant from spending half the word budget on an attractive opening and rushing the chapter's actual work.

4. Generate options before prose

Use AI first where its abundance is useful.

Ask for:

- Three opening situations with different emotional effects
- Several examples that test the same principle
- Competing objections ranked by seriousness
- Scene complications that arise from established character motives
- Analogies with stated limits
- Alternative transitions

Require brief options, not polished pages. Compare them against the chapter brief. Combine, reject, or rewrite.

WARNING

Option generation is not source generation. A plausible statistic or quotation is not an option to use. It is an unverified lead.

5. Draft one section

Give the assistant:

- Relevant context-reset packet
- Approved internal map
- Exact section to draft
- Word range
- Required source or scene facts
- Voice constraints
- Prohibitions
- Output format

Example instruction:

Draft only the 450-600-word section that distinguishes restraint from passivity. Use the approved online-retaliation situation. Preserve the defined meaning of strength. Do not quote Scripture, introduce a new theological claim, diagnose anger, or conclude the chapter. End by creating the question the next section answers.

The boundaries make review possible.

6. Review the section

Review in this order:

Function

Does the section do its assigned job? Remove material that belongs to another section, even if it is good.

Truth and continuity

Verify claims, quotations, sources, character facts, timeline, and terminology. Verify every quotation outside the AI assistant. For Scripture, open the selected translation and confirm the wording and reference.

Reasoning

Does the conclusion follow? Has the draft skipped a difficult step? Does an example prove less than the prose claims?

Voice

Does it sound like this author and this book? Identify generic transitions, symmetrical lists, inflated conclusions, and repeated sentence patterns.

Movement

Does the ending create the next needed question or story state?

Only after those checks should you polish individual sentences.

7. Approve, revise, or reject

Use three clear outcomes:

- **Approve:** The section fulfills its function and can enter the working manuscript.
- **Revise:** The underlying move is sound, but a defined problem must be corrected.
- **Reject:** The section solves the wrong problem, relies on false material, breaks the architecture, or has no recoverable voice.

Do not spend six revisions rescuing a draft that misunderstood the job. Return to the internal map and begin again.

8. Update the system

After approval:

- Add verified claims and sources to the ledger.
- Add new definitions and callbacks to continuity.
- Record decisions that changed during drafting.
- Log problems reserved for later revision passes.
- Update word count against budget.
- At chapter completion, create the chapter handoff.

The operating system stays current because updates happen when decisions are fresh.

When to start a clean conversation

Start a clean conversation when:

- The assistant repeatedly follows an old instruction that is no longer valid.
- The conversation contains several rejected directions.
- The model confuses chapters, characters, or versions.
- A new phase requires a different role, such as moving from brainstorming to verification.
- You spend more effort correcting context than supplying it.
- The current task can be described more clearly with a fresh context-reset packet.

Do not treat one chat as the book. Your external documents are the book's memory.

Fiction drafting controls

FICTION

For every scene, track:

- Viewpoint character
- Scene goal
- Opposition
- Information available to each character
- Emotional starting state
- Choice or reversal
- Physical and temporal continuity

- Ending state
- Setup or payoff affected

Ask AI for scene options grounded in established motives. Reject conflict that requires a character to become temporarily foolish. Reject surprises that violate world rules or appear without setup.

After a scene, update character knowledge. A later chapter cannot conceal information the viewpoint character already learned.

Nonfiction drafting controls

NONFICTION

For every argument move, track:

- Claim
- Evidence
- Source quality
- Explanation of how the evidence supports the claim
- Limitation
- Reasonable objection
- Application

Separate illustrative stories from evidence. A personal account can make a principle memorable without proving that the principle is universally true.

Do not let confident prose widen a narrow source. If a study concerns one population, the manuscript cannot silently apply it to everyone.

Biblical-project drafting controls

BIBLICAL PROJECT

Use this order when a section depends on Scripture:

1. Identify the passage and translation policy.
2. Read and record the immediate context.
3. Record observations about the text.
4. State the interpretation the author is adopting.
5. Identify the theological framework when the conclusion depends on it.
6. Draw the principle with appropriate limits.
7. Create a modern application.
8. Review the application for age, safety, and unintended harm.

Verify every quotation and reference manually. Never ask a model to "quote the verse from memory" and publish the result.

Writing across ages 13-21

Write the main prose to the chosen midpoint. Vary examples rather than switching voices.

For a chapter on work:

-
- A younger example may involve chores completed without supervision.
 - A middle example may involve a first job and admitting a mistake.
 - An older example may involve money, schedule, or responsibility to coworkers.

The principle remains stable while responsibility expands.

Challenge without shame

Challenge names responsibility and a next action. Shame turns struggle into identity and often makes honesty less safe.

Prefer:

Courage may begin with telling a trusted adult what has been happening.

Avoid:

A real man handles his own problems.

The second sentence can isolate a reader facing danger, abuse, addiction, or mental-health distress. Qualified human review is required for sensitive guidance.

Application without overreach

Application should answer:

- What can the reader notice?
- What decision can the reader make?
- What action is safe and appropriate?
- Who can help?
- What outcome is not promised?

The book can call a reader toward faithfulness. It cannot guarantee a particular response from family, friends, employers, romantic interests, or God.

Managing word count during drafting

Track three numbers:

- Planned words
- Approved words
- Revision variance

If a chapter exceeds its maximum, diagnose before cutting:

- Did the chapter acquire a second job?
- Is the same idea explained more than once?
- Are examples doing identical work?
- Did background research replace the reader's actual need?
- Does a section belong in another chapter or appendix?

If a chapter is too short, do not inflate it. Check for missing evidence, missing complication, insufficient application, or an unresolved dependency.

A complete chapter session

A disciplined session can follow this sequence:

1. Read the chapter brief and current handoff.
2. Select one internal move.
3. Load only relevant context.
4. Resolve one author decision.
5. Generate brief options if needed.
6. Choose and adapt the option.
7. Draft the section.
8. Review function, truth, reasoning, voice, and movement.
9. Approve, revise, or reject.
10. Update ledgers and trackers.
11. Record the next exact task.

Stopping with a clear next task is more valuable than exhausting yourself into three additional pages of uncontrolled prose.

Chapter handoff checklist

At chapter completion, record:

- Final chapter job and word count
- Reader or character movement
- Claims and sources introduced
- Definitions established
- Fiction facts or nonfiction promises created
- Questions deferred
- Revision issues logged
- Next chapter dependency
- One-paragraph summary

The chapter handoff lets the next chapter begin from reality rather than memory.

Part V: Revise in Controlled Passes

Revision becomes unreliable when the instruction is simply "make this better." Better in what way? A cleaner sentence cannot repair a missing premise. A warmer tone cannot verify a quotation. A shorter paragraph cannot fix a chapter in the wrong position.

Revise one dimension at a time. Each pass has a question, evidence, and completion test.

Pass 1: Promise and structure pass

Question: Does the manuscript deliver the book promise in a coherent sequence?

Review chapter summaries before individual paragraphs. Mark chapters that repeat a function, depend on missing material, arrive too early, or do not change the reader or story.

Completion test:

- Every part has a clear movement.
- Every chapter has a distinct primary job.
- Dependencies appear before use.
- The middle increases difficulty or pressure.
- The ending completes the promise.

Pass 2: Chapter-purpose and sequence pass

Compare each chapter to its approved brief. Identify sections that migrated from another chapter, openings that restart the whole book, and endings that merely summarize.

Create a one-sentence handoff between adjacent chapters: "Because Chapter 8 established X, Chapter 9 can now ask Y." If the sentence cannot be written, inspect the transition or order.

Pass 3: Continuity or argument pass

FICTION

Check character knowledge, motivation, injuries, objects, travel, time, setting rules, emotional states, setup, and payoff. Read each major character's scenes as a separate sequence.

NONFICTION

Check definitions, claims, examples, objections, practices, and cross-references. Confirm that recurring terms keep the same meaning or that changes are explicitly developed.

Pass 4: Evidence and citation pass

Return to every claim-and-source record. Open the source. Confirm that it supports the sentence as written. Verify names, dates, numbers, quotation marks, page locations, and bibliography details.

AI cannot perform the final evidence and citation pass by inspecting its own output. It can help create a claim inventory, but a human must return to the sources.

BIBLICAL PROJECT

Perform a theological consistency review and a Scripture-in-context review. Check every reference against the chosen translation policy. Confirm the manuscript distinguishes observation, interpretation, theological conclusion, and application. Ask a qualified human reviewer to examine the treatment of disputed passages and sensitive doctrine.

Pass 5: Voice and audience pass

Read for relationship, not just style. Is the author speaking with the reader, at the reader, or past the reader?

For the biblical project, perform a youth-audience suitability review:

- Is the language understandable without becoming childish?
- Do examples acknowledge different stages from 13 through 21?
- Does challenge preserve dignity?

-
- Does the book invite honest help-seeking?
 - Are family and church situations treated with appropriate complexity?
 - Could any instruction isolate a reader who is unsafe?

Read representative pages aloud. Mark sentences the author would never naturally say.

Pass 6: Repetition and compression pass

AI drafts commonly repeat at four levels:

- The same claim in different chapters
- The same explanation within a chapter
- The same sentence structure within a page
- The same conclusion at the end of every section

Build a list of key claims by chapter. Decide whether each repetition deepens, applies, recalls, or merely restates. Cut or combine accidental repetition.

Compression is not making every sentence short. It is removing words that do not change meaning, rhythm, emphasis, or relationship.

Pass 7: AI-tell pass

Search for patterns, not forbidden words:

- Generic scene-setting such as "in today's fast-paced world"
- Repeated three-item lists
- Constant contrast formulas: "not X, but Y"
- Inflated transitions and conclusions
- Equal paragraph lengths and overly symmetrical sections
- Abstract encouragement after every difficult point
- Excessive explanation of familiar ideas
- False balance between positions with different evidence
- Unearned certainty

Do not mechanically delete every pattern. Decide whether it reflects the author's intention or the model's default rhythm.

Pass 8: Sentence-level polish

Only now revise sentences for clarity, rhythm, precision, and emphasis.

Prefer concrete subjects and verbs. Replace vague references. Vary sentence length intentionally. Confirm pronouns and antecedents. Remove metaphors that compete. Preserve useful roughness when it carries voice.

Give an AI assistant short passages and explicit constraints. Require it to explain proposed changes or return a comparison table. Never replace the manuscript wholesale at this stage.

Pass 9: Read-aloud and final human review

Read the manuscript aloud or listen to a careful text-to-speech pass while following the text. Mark breath problems, hidden repetition, tone shifts, and sentences that are technically correct but emotionally false.

Use several human reviewers with defined roles:

-
- Developmental reader for structure and promise
 - Subject expert for factual or professional accuracy
 - Theological reviewer for biblical interpretation and consistency
 - Youth-informed reader for age, tone, and safety
 - Copyeditor or proofreader for language and consistency

One reader may fill more than one role, but the roles should not disappear.

Revision requests that work

Weak: "Make this more engaging."

Stronger:

Diagnose this section only for distance from the reader. Identify abstract claims that lack a concrete situation, moments where the voice becomes parental or shaming, and paragraphs that repeat rather than advance. Do not rewrite. Return location, diagnosis, reader effect, and two revision options.

The author reviews the diagnosis before requesting prose.

Revision gate

The manuscript advances to assembly only when:

- All nine passes are complete.
- Open structural problems are resolved.
- Claims and quotations are verified.
- Continuity trackers agree with the manuscript.
- Sensitive guidance has qualified review.
- No unresolved issue is hidden inside a comment or chat.

Part VI: Assemble and Finish the Manuscript

Chapters written separately do not automatically become a book. Assembly reveals duplicated openings, missing transitions, conflicting definitions, inconsistent formatting, and changes in voice that were invisible inside individual files.

1. Establish version control

Version control means knowing which manuscript is current, what changed, and how to recover an earlier state.

Use:

- One current assembly file
- Numbered chapter files
- Dates or version numbers

-
- A changelog for major revisions
 - An archive for superseded files
 - Regular backups in a separate location

Do not overwrite the only recoverable copy. Do not use "final" as a version system.

2. Create a chapter-status dashboard

Track each chapter through:

- Brief approved
- Draft complete
- Sources verified
- Structural revision complete
- Voice revision complete
- Human review complete
- Final proof complete

The dashboard exposes false completion. A chapter with polished sentences but unverified sources is not finished.

3. Assemble approved chapters

Combine only approved chapter versions. Preserve heading levels and intentional section breaks. Add temporary page breaks between chapters, then remove layout artifacts after the manuscript format is chosen.

Create an assembly log containing the source filename and version for every imported chapter.

4. Repair transitions

Read the final two pages of one chapter and the first two pages of the next. Check:

- Does the next chapter reintroduce the whole book?
- Does it assume information the prior chapter removed?
- Does the emotional or argumentative movement continue?
- Are repeated examples now adjacent?
- Does the transition promise the correct next step?

Write transitions after assembly, not in isolation.

5. Complete front and back matter

Depending on the book, prepare:

- Title and copyright pages
- Dedication or epigraph with verified permission
- Contents
- Introduction or preface
- Notes
- Bibliography
- Acknowledgments

-
- Discussion or reflection guide
 - About the author
 - Resource and help information for sensitive topics

BIBLICAL PROJECT

State the Bible translation policy. Identify when quotations come from a named translation. Include source and permissions information required by the publisher. Explain that the book offers general formation and does not replace pastoral, medical, mental-health, or legal care.

6. Prepare the beta-reader edition

Give beta readers a stable manuscript and a defined role. Ask questions tied to the book's promise:

- Where did your attention weaken?
- Which chapter felt repetitive or misplaced?
- Which term remained unclear?
- Where did the tone feel shaming, childish, vague, or performative?
- Which application felt realistic or unrealistic?
- What did the book seem to promise but never deliver?

Do not ask every reader to solve every problem.

7. Triage feedback

Sort feedback into:

- Clear defect
- Pattern reported by several readers
- Reader preference
- Conflict with the book promise
- New idea for another project

The author decides. Feedback is evidence about reader experience, not a vote on every sentence.

8. Complete the final audit

Before export, verify:

- Title, subtitle, author name, and metadata
- Contents and page references
- Heading hierarchy
- Chapter order and numbering
- Cross-references
- Quotations and permissions
- Notes and bibliography
- Scripture references and translation labels
- Spelling of names and defined terms

-
- Repeated or missing text at file joins
 - Images, captions, and accessibility text if used
 - Disclosure choices required by the publisher or author
 - Clean source files and recoverable backups

9. Export and inspect

Export the manuscript to its delivery format. Never assume a successful export is a correct export.

Inspect:

- First and last page
- Every chapter opening
- Pages with tables, callouts, or long quotations
- Widows, orphans, clipping, and unexpected blank pages
- Headers, footers, and page numbers
- Embedded links and bookmarks
- Searchable text and readable characters

The book is complete when the artifact has been inspected, not when the export button has been pressed.

Worked Examples: From Decision to Draft

These examples show how the system's documents connect. They demonstrate process rather than finished chapters.

Nonfiction example: Strength Under Control

BIBLICAL PROJECT

The project is a 60,000-word nonfiction book defining biblical manhood for sons and young men ages 13-21. The primary reader is sixteen or seventeen. The chapter **Strength Under Control** sits in the foundations section.

Book promise excerpt

Help young men understand biblical manhood as identity expressed through responsibility, courage, restraint, service, integrity, and faithful action, using Scripture in context and realistic modern situations.

Project-bible rules used

- Challenge without shame.
- Direct quotations must be checked against the named Bible translation.
- Observation, interpretation, theological choice, and application remain distinct.
- The main prose speaks to the midpoint reader; examples vary by age.
- Sensitive guidance directs readers toward trustworthy adults and qualified help.
- Strength is never equated with domination, silence, or immunity to fear.

Architecture entry

Part II establishes foundations. Earlier chapters define identity and responsibility. This chapter distinguishes controlled strength from domination and passivity. Later chapters apply the distinction to anger, relationships, authority, and leadership.

Chapter brief

Primary job: Replace the idea that strength means domination with strength governed by love, wisdom, and responsibility.

Beginning state: The reader may associate manhood with physical power, emotional hardness, winning, or control.

Ending state: The reader can identify restraint as an active use of strength and choose one restrained response in a realistic conflict.

Internal moves:

1. Online humiliation and the impulse to retaliate
2. Why retaliation feels like strength
3. Source and Scripture work completed by the author
4. Restraint versus passivity
5. A complication involving danger or abuse
6. A practical response process
7. Reflection and transition to courage

Exclusions: No diagnosis, legal advice, invented testimony, universal promise, or unverified quotation.

Review required: Theology, Scripture context, youth suitability, and safety.

Context-reset packet excerpt

We are drafting only the section "Restraint is not passivity." The reader already understands responsibility as ownership of the next faithful action. Explain that restraint can include speaking, reporting harm, setting a boundary, or seeking protection. Do not imply that enduring abuse is virtuous. Use no direct Bible quotation in this section. Write 450-550 words and end with the question: how can a young man know when to wait and when to act?

Draft review

Suppose the generated draft says: "A strong man never lets another person's words control his emotions."

The sentence should not be approved unchanged.

- **Function:** It attempts to define restraint.
- **Reasoning problem:** "Never" creates an impossible standard and treats emotional response as voluntary control.
- **Audience problem:** A struggling reader may hear shame rather than agency.
- **Revision direction:** Separate feeling from action. The reader may feel anger and still choose a response.

A better author-controlled direction is: "Restraint does not mean you feel nothing. It means anger does not get the final vote on what you do next."

Ledger update

- Definition added: restraint is active governance of response, not absence of emotion.

-
- Safety note added: restraint does not require remaining silent in danger or abuse.
 - Later dependency: Chapter 16 applies this definition to conflict and repair.
 - Voice note: avoid "real men never" formulas.

Chapter handoff excerpt

The chapter establishes that strength becomes trustworthy when it is governed. It distinguishes restraint from passivity and prepares the reader for courage as faithful action under fear. The anger chapter must preserve the feeling/action distinction. The leadership chapter must not redefine strength as influence or status.

Fiction example: Mara and the Flood Map

FICTION

Mara is a teenage mapmaker in a city that floods higher each year. She believes her missing brother abandoned the family. When a coded map appears after a workshop flood, she must work with Tomas, the rival apprentice she blames for the disappearance.

Fiction promise

A mystery adventure about a young mapmaker who must choose truth over vindication while uncovering why her brother vanished and who benefits from the city's rising water.

Project-bible rules used

- Viewpoint stays close third person with Mara except for two approved interludes.
- Flood levels and travel times follow the city map.
- Mara notices spatial details before emotional ones.
- Tomas knows the brother investigated the gates but does not know why he disappeared.
- The coded map cannot reveal the final answer before Chapter 17.

Chapter brief

Chapter 6 job: Force Mara to accept Tomas as a temporary partner.

Beginning state: Mara has the map but cannot read the tide notation. She believes Tomas helped her brother leave.

Scene goal: Reach the old gauge house before the evening surge.

Obstacle: The safe bridge is closed, and Tomas knows an illegal route.

Choice: Mara can follow him or lose the day's only access window.

Ending state: She follows him but secretly marks the route in case he betrays her.

Continuity: Mara's left hand is bandaged; Tomas has not seen the full map; sunset surge begins at 18:40.

Context-reset packet excerpt

Draft only the crossing scene from Mara's viewpoint. Preserve her bandaged left hand and tendency to notice space before emotion. Tomas must solve the route problem without becoming suddenly charming. Mara chooses to follow because the time window closes, not because she trusts him. Do not reveal what Tomas knows about her brother. End when Mara notices he has deliberately taken the more dangerous position.

Draft review

If the draft lets Mara leap between roofs using both hands, it fails physical continuity. If Tomas confesses his entire connection to the brother, it violates the reveal plan. If Mara follows because she senses he is "good deep down," the scene replaces a pressured choice with unsupported intuition.

The approved version must preserve motive, knowledge, body, geography, and ending state.

Tracker update

- Mara learns Tomas knows the illegal canal routes.
- Tomas sees only the upper-left corner of the coded map.
- Mara marks Route C in charcoal.
- The bandage becomes wet and must matter in Chapter 7.
- Setup added: Tomas takes the exposed position without explanation.
- Payoff scheduled: Chapter 11 reveals why he fears deep water.

What both examples prove

The genres differ, but the operating logic is the same:

1. The project bible establishes stable rules.
2. Architecture gives the chapter a job.
3. The brief defines movement and boundaries.
4. The context packet supplies only relevant memory.
5. Drafting occurs in a controlled unit.
6. Review tests function before polish.
7. Trackers preserve what changed.
8. The handoff prepares the next chapter.

The AI assistant contributes options and prose. The author controls meaning, truth, continuity, and approval.

Working Templates

Copy these pages into the system where you write. Each template records an author decision or protects a form of manuscript memory.

TEMPLATE

Book Promise Worksheet

Purpose: Define the specific reader experience or transformation the book must deliver.

Complete the reader, problem, change, approach, and exclusion fields. Write three versions, then approve one sentence.

Primary reader	
Starting problem	
Desired change	
Distinct approach	
What the book will not promise	
Approved promise	

EXERCISE

Worked example

For young men ages 13-21, explain biblical manhood as identity expressed through responsibility, courage, restraint, service, integrity, and faithful action.

Reader Profile and Transformation

Purpose: Write to a specific person and define observable progress.

Choose a primary developmental midpoint. Describe before, understand, practice, and continue states.

Primary age and stage	
Existing beliefs	
Private fears	
Natural language	
Before	
Understand	
Practice	
Continue	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Primary reader: age 16-17. Before: confuses manhood with approval or toughness. Practice: can choose one responsible action under pressure.

Master Project Bible

Purpose: Preserve the manuscript's stable decisions outside any AI conversation.

Record only approved project-level decisions. Move exploration and rejected ideas elsewhere.

Title	
Promise	
Reader	
Scope	
Exclusions	
Parts	
Voice rules	
Evidence policy	
Sensitive boundaries	
Open questions	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Voice rule: challenge without shame. Evidence policy: Scripture wording is checked in the named translation before use.

60,000-Word Architecture

Purpose: Allocate the manuscript across purposeful parts before drafting.

Give each part a function, chapter range, target words, starting state, and ending state. Total the targets.

Part	
Function	
Chapters	
Target words	
Starting state	
Ending state	
Dependencies	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Part II - Foundations; Chapters 5-9; 12,000 words; moves from identity to a working definition of disciplined strength.

Chapter Map and Word Budget

Purpose: Give every chapter one primary job and a visible share of the total length.

List each chapter once. If two chapters have the same job, merge or differentiate them.

Number	
Working title	
Primary job	
Dependency	
Target words	
Minimum	
Maximum	
Status	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Chapter 5 - Strength Under Control; distinguish restraint from domination and passivity; 2,500-word target.

Chapter Brief

Purpose: Create a drafting contract between architecture and prose.

Approve the brief before drafting. Revise it openly if the chapter's job changes.

Primary job	
Beginning state	
Ending state	
Required material	
Exclusions	
Internal moves	
Opening	
Closing	
Word budget	
Review needs	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Ending state: the reader can name one situation where restraint is active courage rather than passivity.

Style and Voice Sheet

Purpose: Define voice through observable behavior instead of flattering adjectives.

Write rules, prohibitions, and short approved examples. Keep the sheet brief enough to reuse.

Point of view	
Reader relationship	
Directness	
Sentence habits	
Vocabulary	
Uncertainty	
Humor	
Avoid	
Approved samples	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Avoid: 'A real man never struggles.' Prefer agency: 'Your struggle does not remove your responsibility for the next choice.'

Context-Reset Packet

Purpose: Start a clean conversation with the smallest accurate context for one task.

Include only relevant project rules, brief material, tracker facts, and the exact requested output.

Book promise	
Current location	
Relevant rules	
Chapter brief	
Prior summary	
Tracker facts	
Voice sample	
Exact task	
Output format	
Forbidden decisions	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Draft only the 450-550-word distinction between restraint and passivity. Do not quote Scripture or conclude the chapter.

Decision Log

Purpose: Prevent important questions from being repeatedly reopened or silently changed.

Record the question, options, final decision, reason, affected files, and review trigger.

Date	
Question	
Options	
Decision	
Reason	
Affected documents	
Review trigger	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Decision: write to age 16-17 as the midpoint, then vary examples for younger and older readers.

Fiction Character Tracker

Purpose: Preserve character identity, desire, knowledge, relationships, and change.

Update only after material is approved. Track what the character knows by chapter.

Character	
Want	
Need	
Fear	
Misbelief	
Voice	
Physical facts	
Relationships	
Knowledge by chapter	
Arc status	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Mara notices spatial details before emotional ones and does not know why her brother disappeared.

Fiction Timeline and Continuity

Purpose: Control time, location, objects, injuries, setups, and payoffs.

Add one row per scene. Flag any fact that a later scene must preserve.

Scene	
Date/time	
Location	
Viewpoint	
Characters	
Objects	
Injuries	
Knowledge change	
Setup	
Payoff	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Chapter 6: Mara's left hand remains bandaged; Tomas sees only one corner of the coded map.

Nonfiction Claim-and-Source Ledger

Purpose: Connect every meaningful factual claim to a source a human has opened and checked.

Treat model suggestions as leads only. Record exact locations and whether the source supports the wording.

Claim ID	
Claim	
Chapter	
Source	
Source type	
Location	
Support level	
Verified date	
Quotation status	
Limitations	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Status remains lead only until the author opens the source and confirms the claim at the recorded page.

Biblical Citation and Interpretation Ledger

Purpose: Keep biblical text, observation, interpretation, doctrine, and application distinct.

Verify direct wording in the chosen translation. Identify the author's interpretive and theological choices.

Passage	
Translation	
Verified wording	
Context	
Observation	
Interpretation	
Alternative view	
Theological source	
Principle	
Application	
Reviewer	
Status	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Application is recorded separately from the passage observation and receives youth-suitability review.

Drafting-Session Checklist

Purpose: Keep each drafting session attached to an approved purpose.

Complete before, during, and after one controlled section.

Brief reviewed	
Blocking decision resolved	
Section selected	
Context loaded	
Word range	
Review complete	
Approved/revised/rejected	
Trackers updated	
Next task	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Next task: draft the 300-word complication explaining why restraint is not silence in danger.

Chapter Handoff Summary

Purpose: Transfer the real ending state of one chapter into the next chapter's work.

Write after the chapter is approved. Keep it concise and factual.

Chapter job	
Final words	
Reader/character movement	
Claims/scenes	
Definitions/facts	
Decisions	
Promises	
Open problems	
Next dependency	
Summary	

EXERCISE

Worked example

The anger chapter must preserve the distinction between feeling anger and choosing action.

Structural Revision Checklist

Purpose: Review the book's promise, sequence, dependencies, middle, and ending before line editing.

Use chapter summaries first. Record moves and deletions before editing prose.

Promise delivered	
Distinct chapter jobs	
Dependencies ordered	
Middle escalates	
Repetition mapped	
Ending completes movement	
Changes approved	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Chapters 7 and 12 repeat the same definition; Chapter 12 will become an application under pressure.

Voice and AI-Tell Checklist

Purpose: Find model-default rhythm and restore the author's relationship with the reader.

Mark patterns in context. Do not delete mechanically; decide whether each pattern is intentional.

Generic framing	
Repeated list shape	
Inflated transition	
Abstract encouragement	
Unearned certainty	
Symmetry	
Author sample comparison	
Read-aloud result	

EXERCISE

Worked example

Three consecutive sections end with motivational summary paragraphs; keep one and replace two with forward movement.

Final Manuscript Audit

Purpose: Verify content and artifact integrity before publication.

Complete after assembly and again after export.

Metadata	
Contents	
Order	
Cross-references	
Sources	
Permissions	
Scripture policy	
Names/terms	
Join errors	
Headers/footers	
Links	
Backups	
Human reviews	

EXERCISE

Worked example

All direct Bible quotations match the named translation and required permissions language is present.

Prompt Framework Library

These frameworks organize decisions. Replace the example inputs with current project documents and verify every factual result outside the model.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Premise or Thesis Test

Stage: Foundation

Inputs: Three candidate promises; Reader profile; Scope boundaries

The author decides: Which promise the book will make.

Compare the candidate promises for specificity, reader fit, credible transformation, distinct approach, and exclusions. Diagnose; do not choose for me.

Output: Table with strengths, risks, hidden assumptions, and author questions.

The model must not decide: The final promise, belief, or moral position.

Example: Compare three versions of the biblical-manhood promise and flag any outcome the book cannot guarantee.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Outline Stress Test

Stage: Architecture

Inputs: Book promise; Part functions; Chapter map; Dependencies

The author decides: Which structural changes to approve.

Act as a skeptical developmental editor. Identify duplicated jobs, missing dependencies, weak middle movement, and chapters that do not advance the promise. Do not rewrite the outline.

Output: Issue, evidence, reader consequence, and two possible author decisions.

The model must not decide: Chapter additions, deletions, order, or final scope.

Example: Flag whether work, discipline, and responsibility repeat rather than develop.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Chapter Brief Builder

Stage: Architecture

Inputs: Project bible; Outline entry; Prior handoff; Target words

The author decides: The chapter's primary job and ending state.

Propose three distinct chapter-brief options that preserve the supplied architecture. Keep required facts separate from suggestions.

Output: Three concise briefs using the approved brief fields.

The model must not decide: Theological stance, source validity, plot meaning, or final brief.

Example: Offer three ways Strength Under Control can move from misconception to practical discernment.

Fiction Scene Options

Stage: Drafting

Inputs: Scene brief; Character tracker; Continuity facts; World rules

The author decides: Which scene path expresses the story's meaning.

Generate four scene complications grounded in established motives and rules. State the pressure, choice, consequence, and continuity cost.

Output: Four short option cards.

The model must not decide: Character meaning, canon changes, or final scene choice.

Example: Give Mara four reasons she must accept Tomas's route without suddenly trusting him.

Nonfiction Argument Map

Stage: Drafting

Inputs: Chapter brief; Verified claim records; Defined terms; Reader state

The author decides: Which claims and evidence the chapter will use.

Map a sequence of claim, evidence, explanation, limitation, objection, application, and transition using only supplied verified material.

Output: Numbered argument moves with missing-evidence flags.

The model must not decide: Truth of unverified claims or adequacy of a source not supplied.

Example: Map restraint versus passivity without introducing a verse or psychological claim.

Draft From an Approved Brief

Stage: Drafting

Inputs: Context packet; Approved internal move; Voice sheet; Word range

The author decides: Whether the draft is approved, revised, or rejected.

Draft only the named section within the word range. Preserve all required facts and prohibitions. End at the specified handoff point.

Output: Prose only, followed by a three-line compliance note.

The model must not decide: New claims, new canon, chapter conclusion, or changes to the brief.

Example: Draft 450-550 words distinguishing restraint from passivity; do not quote Scripture or conclude the chapter.

Context Reset and Handoff

Stage: Operating System

Inputs: Project bible excerpt; Chapter brief; Trackers; Prior handoff; Exact task

The author decides: Which context is relevant and current.

Confirm the task, list the constraints you will preserve, list missing information, and wait for approval before drafting.

Output: Task statement, constraints, missing information, and no prose draft.

The model must not decide: Which conflicting document is authoritative.

Example: Begin a clean Chapter 6 fiction session using only current facts about Mara, Tomas, and the route.

Continuity Audit

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Manuscript section; Continuity tracker; Timeline; Definitions

The author decides: How to resolve each confirmed conflict.

Find contradictions between the supplied manuscript and control records. Quote the minimum text needed to identify each location. Do not repair automatically.

Output: Location, control fact, manuscript fact, severity, and resolution question.

The model must not decide: Which version becomes canon.

Example: Check whether Mara uses her bandaged hand and whether Tomas knows more than the tracker allows.

Source and Claim Audit

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Chapter; Claim-and-source ledger

The author decides: Whether a claim stays, narrows, receives a source, or is removed.

Inventory factual and causal claims. Match each to a supplied ledger ID. Flag claims with no record or wording broader than the source note. Do not verify using memory.

Output: Claim, location, ledger ID, status, and required human action.

The model must not decide: That a source is authoritative or correctly quoted.

Example: Flag every empirical claim in a chapter aimed at young readers for manual source review.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Voice Comparison

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Draft passage; Voice sheet; Approved author sample

The author decides: Which differences are defects and which are intentional.

Compare behavior rather than topic: directness, rhythm, vocabulary, uncertainty, examples, and endings. Diagnose without rewriting.

Output: Behavior, draft evidence, sample evidence, reader effect, and revision choice.

The model must not decide: What the author's authentic voice is.

Example: Identify where the biblical-project draft becomes shaming or generically motivational.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Repetition Detection

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Chapter summaries; Key claims; Manuscript text

The author decides: Which repetitions deepen, reinforce, move, combine, or disappear.

Cluster repeated claims and examples. Distinguish developmental return from accidental restatement.

Output: Cluster, locations, function, reader effect, and options.

The model must not decide: Which passage to delete.

Example: Compare every definition of responsibility across the 24-chapter map.

PROMPT FRAMEWORK

Developmental Edit

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Book promise; Architecture; Chapter summaries; Open issues

The author decides: Structural revisions and their priority.

Evaluate promise delivery, sequence, dependency, escalation, balance, and ending. Cite the supplied structure. Do not line edit.

Output: High, medium, and low priority findings with evidence and author questions.

The model must not decide: The book's final structure or beliefs.

Example: Assess whether the biblical-manhood middle moves from private practice to relational pressure.

Constrained Line Edit

Stage: Revision

Inputs: Approved passage; Voice sheet; Protected facts and terms

The author decides: Which edits enter the manuscript.

Suggest sentence-level changes for clarity, rhythm, and precision. Preserve facts, claims, terms, and meaning. Explain material changes.

Output: Original excerpt, proposed revision, reason, and risk.

The model must not decide: New claims, examples, theology, plot facts, or structural changes.

Example: Edit one approved page without changing the definition of restraint or its safety limitation.

Chapter Summary and Tracker Update

Stage: Handoff

Inputs: Approved chapter; Brief; Current trackers

The author decides: Which extracted changes are accurate and approved.

Extract the chapter's accomplished job, ending state, new definitions or facts, promises, open issues, and proposed tracker updates. Do not infer unstated canon.

Output: Completed handoff fields plus proposed tracker rows.

The model must not decide: Whether the chapter is approved or whether an inference becomes canon.

Example: Summarize Strength Under Control and identify later chapters that must preserve its definitions.

Final Principle

AI may generate pages. The author controls the book.

Your name belongs on the manuscript because you accepted responsibility for its promise, structure, truth, voice, judgment, and final language.